

Elektra

From Sophocles to Richard Strauss

Hector Li

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Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and Instrumentation

Fragmentary Thoughts on the Opera Itself

Relations with Other Works

Trivia and Anecdotes

Recommended Reading

Acknowledgement

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Overview I

Elektra

Hector Li

Elektra, Op. 58, is a one-act opera by Richard Strauss, to a German-language libretto by the Austrian writer Hugo von Hofmannsthal. Hofmannsthal wrote the libretto based on his 1903 drama *Elektra*. The opera was the first of many collaborations between Strauss and Hofmannsthal. *Elektra* was first performed at the Königliches Opernhaus on 25 January 1909. The first United States performance of the opera in the original German was given by the Philadelphia Grand Opera Company at the Academy of Music on 29 October 1931.

Since its premiere, the reception of the opera has been divided. The reception of *Elektra* in German-speaking countries was mostly divided amongst traditionalist and modernist lines. Some contemporary critics vitrolically attacked its exploration of dark and primal mentality, such as obsession with murderous violence and ruthless revenge. One

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Overview II

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

commentator even claimed, “The whole thing impresses one as a sexual aberration.”

Meanwhile, other critics approved the modernist techniques in the opera. When later Strauss and Hofmannsthal staged their popular *Der Rosenkavalier*, some claimed that Strauss had lost genius inspirations and innovations in *Salome* and *Elektra* and instead chose to write on cliché topics. For example, Charles Rosen praises Strauss for his disinterested courage in writing *Salome* and *Elektra* with “their extreme chromaticism and . . . their representation of pathological state” and accuses him of “final cowardice because he then “quickly retreated into 18th-century pastiche and the delicious Viennese pastry of *Der Rosenkavalier*.”

Electra's family bears the curse of killing kinsmen. The curse starts when her ancestor Tantalus kills his son Pelops and serves him as a meal to gods. Disgusted by the nature of the gruesome offering, gods refuse to touch the meat, except for Demeter, who, distraught by the abduction of her daughter Persephone by Hades, absentmindedly eats part of the boy's shoulder. Later gods resurrect Pelops and Hephaestus crafts an ivory shoulder for the boy. As a punishment to his sacrilegious offering, Tantalus is forced to stand in a pool of water beneath a fruit tree with low branches. Whenever he reaches for the fruit, the branches raises his intended meal from his grasp. Whenever he bends down to get a drink, the water recedes before he can get any.

Tantalus has a daughter called Niobe. Proud of her fourteen children, seven sons and seven daughters, she boasts to the Leto, taunting that the goddess only has a son and a daughter. In her indignation, Leto sends Apollo to kill all

Myth

Trivia and Anecdotes

Acknowledgement

Myth II

seven sons and Artemis to kill all seven daughters. In some versions of the myth, all of Niobe's children are killed, and in other versions, the youngest son and daughter are spared. Mourning over the corpses of his children, Amphion, the husband of Niobe either kills himself or is killed by Apollo because of the intention of revenge. Overwhelmed by the grief of losing all her children, Niobe is transformed into a stone on Mount Sipylus.

Pelops, having been resurrected, furthers the curse of the family. After reaching the adulthood, he seeks to marry Hippodamia, the beautiful daughter of King Oenomaus. Fearing the prophecy that he will be killed by his son-in-law, King Oenomaus has killed eighteen suitors of Hippodamia after defeating them in a chariot race and affixes their heads to the wooden columns of his palace. In order to win the chariot race, Pelops seeks help from his former lover Poseidon. Poseidon gifts him with a chariot drawn by

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Elektra

Hector Li

Myth

Trivia and Anecdotes

Acknowledgement

Myth IV

Elektra

Hector Li

the kingdom. Pelops banishes both Atreus and Thyestes and Hippodamia hangs herself because of the despair over the expulsion of her both sons.

After Pelops's death, Atreus and Thyestes competes for the throne. Atreus vows to sacrifice his best lamb to Artemis. Upon searching his flock, however, Atreus discovered a golden lamb which he chooses to give to his wife, Aerope, to hide from the goddess. She gives it to Thyestes, her lover, who then convinces Atreus to agree that whoever has the lamb should be king. Thyestes produces the lamb and claims the throne. Atreus retakes the throne by following the advice he receives from Hermes. Thyestes agrees to give the kingdom back if the sun moves backwards in the sky, a feat that Zeus accomplishes with the help of gods. Atreus retakes the throne and banishes Thyestes. Indignant over the adultery of Aerope and Thyestes, Atreus swears revenge. In Seneca's tragedy *Thyestes*, Atreus reflects with a dark and

[Overview](#)

[Myth](#)

[Synopsis](#)

[Favorite Arias](#)

[Style and
Instrumentation](#)

[Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself](#)

[Relations with
Other Works](#)

[Trivia and
Anecdotes](#)

[Recommended
Reading](#)

[Acknowledgement](#)

Myth V

murderous mind: “This mighty house of famous Pelops itself—let it fall even onto me, so long as it falls onto my brother.” With a false gesture of reconciliation, Atreus recalls Thyestes and promises to share the throne. In Seneca’s tragedy *Thyestes*, Tantalus is forced by a Fury to ignite the hatred between the brothers. When Thyestes returns to Mycenae, Atreus placates him with the crown. Atreus then leads away three sons of Thyestes when their father ponders over the crown and the clothes. Immediately Atreus kills the three boys and prepares a banquet for Thyestes with their bodies. When Thyestes finishes the meal, Atreus shows him the bodiless heads of three boys. Even the gods are angered by this atrocity and turns the entire universe into darkness. Thyestes vows vengeance, but Atreus teases him ruthlessly. Upon learning an oracle that, if he were to have a son with his own daughter, that son would kill Atreus, Thyestes

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

disguises himself and raped Pelopia when she stays with King Thesprotus. However, She manages to pull out his sword and keeps it so she might recognize her offender. Taking Pelopia for a daughter of Thesprotus, Atreus seeks to marry her. Thesprotus consents in order not to reveal the truth. Pelopia soon gives birth to and abandons Aegisthus. Aegisthus is suckled by a she-goat and survives. A shepherd finds Aegisthus and gives him to Atreus, who raises the infant as his own son. When Aegisthus has entered adulthood, Thyestes is captured by Agamemnon and Menelaus at Delphi and brought to Atreus. Atreus sends Aegisthus to kill Thyestes. Aegisthus happens to be carrying the sword that once belonged to Thyestes and was later given to him by Pelopia; Thyestes recognizes the sword and asks Aegisthus about it. Aegisthus calls for Pelopia, who tells him how the weapon has got to her. Upon recognizing Thyestes and the fact that he is the rapist, Pelopia stabs

Myth

herself with her father's sword. Aegisthus then kills Atreus and restores the kingdom to Thyestes.

After he becomes the king, Thyestes exiles Atreus's sons Agamemnon and Menelaus to Sparta. There King Tyndareus accepts them and later helps them to return to Mycenae to overthrow Thyestes. As a token of good will and allegiance, King Tyndareus offers his daughters to Agamemnon and Menelaus as wives, Clytemnestra and Helen respectively. According to Steischorus, while sacrificing to the gods Tyndareus forgets to honor Aphrodite and thus the goddess is angered and makes his daughters twice and thrice wed and deserters of their husbands.

After Helen runs away with Paris, Agamemnon musters a great army. In Aulis, Agamemnon accidentally kills a deer in the grove sacred to Artemis. As a punishment, Artemis stops the flowing of winds. The prophet Calchas in the Greek army interprets the signs and concludes that Agamemnon has to

Myth

Myth VIII

Elektra

Hector Li

sacrifice his daughter Iphigenia to placate the goddess. In Euripides's play *Iphigenia in Aulis* (will be on show in November this semester), having sent a messenger to Argos to fetch Iphigenia on the pretext of a marriage with Achilles, Agamemnon feigns sorrow over the impending loss of his daughter and sends another slowest old servant to revoke the previous message, well conscious of the fact that the old servant cannot reach Argos before Iphigenia arrives in Aulis. The innocent and loving maiden Iphigenia enlists the help from her brother Orestes and her mother Clytemnestra to persuade Agamemnon to spare herself, but staunch with his ambition, Agamemnon refuses to yield. Eventually Iphigenia is coaxed into accepting her fate, and in order to appease his wife, Agamemnon sends a messenger to Clytemnestra to tell a tale where Iphigenia is transported into the heaven and a deer is found on the altar to replace her.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Morose and furious over the death of her daughter, Clytemnestra takes Aegisthus as a lover. In Seneca's *Agamemnon*, Clytemnestra broods over the atrocities of the house: "O house that always outdoes crimes with crimes! We bought the winds with blood, the war with murder! But at least a thousand ships set sail together? No, the fleet was not released with divine favour: Aulis cast the unnatural ships out of its harbour." In Aeschylus's play *Agamemnon*, when Agamemnon finally returns from Troy after ten years, Clytemnestra tricks him into the sacrilegious action of walking on the red carpet. Aegisthus is too afraid to commit the murder. Clytemnestra throws a web over Agamemnon when he is bathing and smashes an axe into his head. Confronting the Argive men, Clytemnestra justifies her action with the revenge for Iphigenia. When the murder takes place, Orestes is abroad. In other versions of the mythology, notably in Sophocles's *Electra*, Orestes is still

Myth

very young and inside the palace. Electra rescues Orestes and gives him to Agamemnon's friends.

After some years, Orestes, under Apollo's threats against the inactivity, returns to Argos and kills Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. In most versions, Orestes begins to be harassed by Furies the moment he sheds his mother's blood. In Aeschylus's *Eumenides*, Orestes is narrowly acquitted by the jury formed in Athens. However, in Euripides's *Iphigenia among Taurians*, some Furies continue to persecute Orestes. Receiving the guidance from Apollo, Orestes sails for Tauris to retrieve Artemis's statue. There, Orestes and his friend Pylades are almost sacrificed by Iphigenia turned into a priestess among the barbarians. After recognizing the kinship, Orestes and Iphigenia, along with Pylades escape the island with the help of Athena.

However, Orestes is also a murderous character in most literature. In Euripides's *Orestes*, Orestes threatens to kill his

Myth

Trivia and Anecdotes

Myth XI

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

cousin Hermione in order to save himself from Tyndareus's charge. In Euripides's *Andromache*, Orestes kills Neoptolemus in order to marry Hermione. Even though most people consider that the curse of Atreus's house ends when Orestes is acquitted in the trial in Athens, I think that the curse is likely to persist.

Synopsis I

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

“Wo bleibt Elektra?” (“Where is Elektra?”)

Five servants try to wash the courtyard of the Palace in Mycenae. While doing their work, they ask where Elektra can be when she emerges from the shadows with a wild look on her face. The servants continue commenting how she came to be in that state and talk about how they taunt her only to receive insults from her. Only one servant shows mercy for her, but she is taken away by the overseer to be flogged.

“Allein! Weh, ganz allein.” (“Alone! Alas, all alone.”)

Elektra comes back for her daily ritual in memory of her father, who upon his return from Troy was killed while bathing by Klytämnestra and Aegisth and dragged out into the courtyard. Elektra now starts imagining the day when her father will be avenged and then of the ensuing celebration in which she will lead the triumphal dance.

“Elektra!”

Synopsis II

Elektra

Hector Li

Chrysothemis leaves the Palace to seek Elektra. Unlike her unyielding sister, Chrysothemis is meek and accommodating, and enjoys the privileges that come with being a Princess. After Agamemnon's murder, Chrysothemis has remained on good terms with Klytämnestra and Aegisth. Chrysothemis warns that Klytämnestra plans to lock Elektra in a tower, but is rebuffed.

“Ich kann nicht sitzen und ins Dunkel starren.” (“I can not sit and stare into the darkness.”)

Chrysothemis does not wish to go on living a half-death and be confined in the palace: she wants to leave, marry and raise children, regardless of the birth and wealth of the husband.

“Es geht ein Lärm los.” (“What tumult is this?”)

As loud sounds are heard inside, Elektra mocks her sister that it is her wedding party.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Hector Li

Synopsis

found the way to appease the gods. But, she claims that every problem has a solution and that once the correct sacrifice is found, she will be able to sleep again.

“Wenn Das rechte Blutopfer unterm Beile fällt.”
(“When the right blood under the hatchet flows.”)

Elektra teases her mother with little pieces of information about the right victim that must be slain, but she changes the conversation to her brother and asks why he is not allowed back. To Elektra's horror, Klytämnestra says that he has become mad and keeps company with animals. She responds that this is not true and that all the gold that her mother has sent was not being used to support her son but to have him killed. Angered by Elektra's evasiveness and unwillingness to cooperate, Klytämnestra threatens that torture will force out the information about the right victim.

“Was bluten muß? Dein eigenes Genick.” (“Who must bleed? Your own throat.”)

Synopsis

Then Elektra reveals who is to be the actual victim: it is Klytämnestra herself. She goes on to describe how the gods must be appeased once and for all. She must be awakened and chased around the house just like an animal that is being hunted. Only when she wishes that all was over and after envying prisoners in their cells, she will come to realize that her prison is her own body. At that time, the axe with which she killed her husband and which will be handed to Orest by Elektra, will fall on her. Only then the dreams will stop.

“Lichter! Mehr Lichter” (“Lights! More lights!”)

The Trainbearer and Confidante enter and whisper to her. Klytämnestra laughs hysterically and, mocking Elektra, leaves. Elektra wonders what has made her mother laugh.

“Orest! Orest ist tot!” (“Orest! Orest is dead!”)

Chrysothemis comes to tell her: two messengers have arrived with the news that Orest is dead, trampled by his own horses. Elektra vehemently tries to deny the factuality of the

Synopsis

Acknowledgement

Synopsis VI

Elektra

Hector Li

message while Chrysothemis laments that no one will care for them.

“Platz da! Wer lungert so vor einer Tür?” (“Give way! Who spies thus upon the threshold?”)

As a young servant comes out of the house to fetch his master Aegisth, he trips over Elektra and Chrysothemis.

“Nun muß es hier von uns geschehn.” (“It is for us to act now.”)

Elektra does not relent. A terrified Chrysothemis listens as her sister demands the help to avenge their father.

“Wie stark du bist.” (“How strong you are.”)

Elektra goes on to praise her sister and her beauty, promising to be a servant at Chrysothemis's bridal chamber in exchange for the assistance in the vengeance. Chrysothemis fights off her sister and flees. Elektra curses her.

“Nun denn, allein!” (“Well, alone!”)

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Synopsis VII

Elektra

Hector Li

Determined to do it alone, Elektra frantically digs for the axe that killed her father, but is interrupted by a mysterious man who comes into the courtyard.

“Was willst du, fremder Mensch?” (“What do you want, stranger?”)

Elektra hears that he is expecting to be called from within the Palace because he has a message for the lady of the house. He claims to be a friend of Orest, and says that he was with him at the time of his death.

“Wer bist denn du?” (“Who are you?”)

Elektra grieves. The man first guesses that she must be a blood relative of Orest and Agamemnon, then, upon asking her name, discovers she is Elektra.

“Orest!”

Then, taken aback, Elektra recognizes him: it is Orest who has come back in disguise. Elektra is initially ecstatic, but

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

also ashamed of what she has become and how she has sacrificed her own royal state for the cause.

“Du wirst es tun? Allein? Du armes Kind?” (“You’ll do it? Alone? Poor child?”)

Orestes Tutor comes and interrupts the siblings; their task is dangerous and anything can jeopardize it. The Trainbearer and Confidante come out of the Palace and lead Orest and the Tutor in.

“Ich habe ihm das Beil nicht geben können!” (“I could not give him the axe!”)

A shout is heard from within the Palace, then a grim moan. Elektra smiles brightly, knowing that Orest has killed their mother.

“He! Lichter!” (“Torches there!”)

Aegisth arrives, he is ecstatic to have heard that Orest is dead and wishes to speak with the messengers. Aegisth suspects the change happening over Elektra, but is overcome

Synopsis

Synopsis IX

Elektra

Hector Li

by the desire to learn Orest's death. Elektra happily ushers Aegisth inside the palace.

“Helft! Mörder!” (“Help! Murder!”)

As Aegisth screams and calls for help, Elektra replies:
“Agamemnon can hear you.”

“Elektra! Schwester!” (“Elektra! Sister!”)

Chrysothemis comes out of the Palace stating that Orest is inside and that he has killed Klytämnestra and Aegisth. A massacre has begun with Orests followers killing those who supported Aegisth and the Queen.

“Ob ich nicht höre?” (“If I do not hear?”)

Elektra is ecstatic and wants to lead the crowd to dance but at first cannot.

“Hörst du denn nicht.” (“You do not hear because.”)

Chrysothemis and Elektra praise their brother's feat.

“Schweig, und tanze.” (“Be silent and dance.”)

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Synopsis X

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

At last Elektra begins to dance. As she reaches the climax of her dance, she falls to the ground: Elektra is dead.
Chrysothemis goes into the Palace to be with her brother.
Banging on the Palace door, she calls for her brother. There is no answer.

Favorite Arias I

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ “Allein! Weh, ganz allein.” This aria is very demanding for sopranos. The ends of the first part and the second part feature high notes and in the second part the singer has to express the frenzy of Elektra. My favorite version is Birgit Nilsson’s performance conducted by Sir Georg Solti in 1968.
- ▶ “Orest!” It is another very exacting aria. The emotion range of this aria is simply stunning. In the interactions before this aria, Elektra falls into the despair over the fabricated death of Orest. After the recognition scene, she simultaneously experiences the joy of meeting her long-lost brother and an elder sister’s love for her younger siblings. Immediately this affection transforms into shame over her own appearance and the lament over her father Agamemnon. Nina Stimmé’s 2016

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Favorite Arias II

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

performance in the Metropolitan is pretty decent, despite the excessive tremor of voice in some parts.

- ▶ “Von jetzt an will ich deine schwester sein.” Accepting the purported death of Orest, Elektra tries to win Chrysothemis’s help by promising to be her servant. The depiction of the imagined marriage scene is probably Elektra’s own suppressed wishes for a happy marriage. Again, Nina Stemme’s 2016 performance in the Metropolitan is pretty good.

Some interesting parts:

- ▶ Klytämnestra needs to express a maniac and hysteric laughter after being informed of Orest’s purported death.
- ▶ Chrysothemis needs to express uncontrolled crying when she runs to inform Elektra of Orest’s fabricated demise.

Style and Instrumentation I

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Musically, *Elektra* deploys dissonance, chromaticism and extremely fluid tonality in a way which recalls but moves beyond the same composer's *Salome* of 1905, and thus *Elektra* represents Strauss's furthest advances in modernism, from which he later retreated. The bitonal or extended *Elektra* chord is a well known dissonance from the opera while harmonic parallelism is also a prominent modernist technique.

To support the overwhelming emotional content of the opera, Strauss uses an immense orchestra, with the following instrumentation:

Style and Instrumentation II

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- ▶ Woodwind: piccolo (doubling fourth flute, although this is omitted from the instrumentation list at the beginning of the score), 3 flutes (flute 3 doubling piccolo 2), 3 oboes (oboe 3 doubling English horn), heckelphone, clarinet in E-flat, 4 clarinets in B-flat and A, 2 bassett horns, bass clarinet, 3 bassoons, contrabassoon;
- ▶ Brass: 8 horns (horns 58 doubling 2 B-flat tenor and 2 F bass Wagner tubas), 6 trumpets, bass trumpet, 2 tenor trombones, bass trombone, contrabass trombone, tuba;
- ▶ Percussion: 68 timpani (2 players), snare drum, bass drum (with switch), cymbals, tam-tam, triangle, tambourine, castanets, glockenspiel;
- ▶ Keyboards: celesta (ad libitum);

Style and Instrumentation III

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

**Style and
Instrumentation**

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- Strings: 2 harps (doubled if possible at the end), 24 violins divided into three groups, 18 violas divided into three groups (the first of which, unusually, doubles as the fourth violin section), 12 cellos divided into two groups, 8 double basses.

Fragmentary Thoughts on the Opera Itself I

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ The opening orchestra is the same as that played in the background when Elektra shouts “Agamemnon hört dich.” I think this repetition possibly resolves the meaning of this motif—Elektra’s call-out to her father Agamemnon. This treatment is also interesting, because Elektra replies “Agamemnon hears you” to Aegisth’s beseeching “Can no one hear me?” The same orchestra plays at the end of the opera repeatedly after Elektra falls dead, possibly signifying that Elektra eventually joins Agamemnon among the dead.
- ▶ The character Elektra stays on the stage for the whole opera. She becomes a centre for conflicts and conveniently appropriates everyone else’s action for herself. The most notable example is the killing of Klytämnestra and Aegisth, where Strauss and

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Fragmentary Thoughts on the Opera Itself II

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

**Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself**

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Hofmannsthal write the part as if Elektra kills Klytämnestra and Aegisth with words.

- ▶ The music is usually eerie and sometimes atonal. The appearance of Klytämnestra onto the stage is scary and ghastly because of the music. The strong music accompanying the recognition scene reflects the dark thoughts of vengeance inside Electra's heart.

Relations with Other Works I

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- *Elektra* deals with similar themes of blood and violence to the sister opera *Salome*. The general atmospheres created by the music are also similar. Both operas explores the relation between dances and death, in *Salome*, the dance of the seven veils and in *Elektra*, Elektra's dance of vengeance. Both opera based on mythic themes talks about maniac love, in *Salome*, Salome's obsession with Jokanaan which leads her to kiss the decapitated head of the prophet and in *Elektra*, Elektra's violent and intense love for Agamemnon. Both opera received great controversy in Strauss's time and widely earns acclaim today.

Relations with Other Works II

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ Chrysothemis's desire to marry any husband, even if only a peasant possibly originates in Euripides's play *Elektra*, where Clytemnestra, fearing the vengeance blade of Elektra's son, marries the princess to a farmer. Respecting Elektra, the farmer never takes advantage of her and assists her in everything. In ancient Greek, Elektra's name means "unbeddable" or "unbedded." In Euripides's *Orestes*, when offering her condolence over Elektra's unmarried status, Helen is actually mocking her with the connotation of the name. In the opera, this theme is more ambiguous. On the one hand, Elektra mocks Chrysothemis's wish to marry. On the other hand, in the recognition scene, Elektra recounts how men desired her beauty. The imagination of Chrysothemis's marriage scene is possibly a projection of Elektra's own wish.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Relations with Other Works III

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ Klytämnestra's nightmares appear in Aeschylus's *Libation Bearers*, Sophocles's *Elektra* and Euripides's *Elektra*, though differing in content.
- ▶ The opera is mainly based on Sophocles's *Elektra*. Chrysothemis and the tutor do not appear in Aeschylus's or Euripides's tragedies. The tale that Orestes is dragged to death is the report the old tutor gives in Sophocles's play. The order where Orest kills Klytämnestra first and then Aegisth matches Sophocles's play. In other plays, after Orestes kills his mother, he is entirely disabled because of the torment of Furies.
- ▶ Curiously, the opera removes the character Pylades that accompanies Orestes in all versions of the myth.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Relations with Other Works V

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- ▶ There is a striking resemblance between Elektra and Antigone. Both characters love their brothers more than sisterly affection. In Euripides's *Orestes*, Elektra and Orestes are almost lovers. In Sophocles's *Antigone*, Antigone expresses a strange idea that she would not do for her husband what he does for Polynices. Elektra is more persistent and stubborn than her sister Chrysothemis, so is Antigone than Ismene. Both Elektra and Antigone show unwavering devotion to their fathers respectively. The opera projects Elektra's romantic desire for her brother Orestes onto her sister Chrysothemis.

Relations with Other Works VI

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ Richard Strauss further develops Wagner's tradition of incorporating myths into the opera. Unlike Wagner's grand and long-winded tales that strive to restruct a mythological world, Hofmannsthal's libretto more closely follows the approaches of ancient tragedy playwrights. He accepts that there are different interpretations and versions of myths, so instead of trying to constructing a systemic world, he simplifies the plot and makes the conflict more concentrated and denser. Following *Elektra*, Strauss worked on other operas dealing with Greek mythology, including *Daphne*.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Trivia and Anecdotes I

Elektra

Hector Li

- ▶ Kirsten Flagstad, the famous Norwegian Wagnerian soprano, never recorded *Salome*, nor any opera by Richard Strauss. She was scheduled to sing the Marschallin in *Der Rosenkavalier* in her debut year at the Metropolitan Opera, but she found a way out of it. She later came to love *Der Rosenkavalier*, but the subject matter was simply too immoral for a well-bred Oslo girl. One of her all-time favourite operas was *Elektra*, and she would have loved to sing it, but the part was simply too obscene for her, so she couldn't bring herself to sing it. However, she did sing "Orest!" in a concert version.
- ▶ Hofmannsthal and Strauss rarely met in person and most of their correspondence were preserved through letters. Strauss occasionally had bitter disputes with Hofmannsthal, but still revered him.

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

Trivia and Anecdotes II

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- ▶ The famous novelist and biographer Stefan Zweig later cooperated with Strauss, writing the libretto for the opera *Die Schweigsame Frau*.
- ▶ Carl Jung proposed the concept of the “Electra complex,” the female counterpart of Sigmund Freud’s Oedipus complex.

Recommended Reading I

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

- ▶ *Agamemnon*, *Libation Bears*, and *Eumenides* by Aeschylus.
- ▶ *Electra*, *Antigone*, and *Oedipus in Colonus* by Sophocles.
- ▶ *Orestes*, *Phoenician Women*, *Iphigenia in Aulis*, *Iphigenia among Taurians*, *Electra* and *Andromache* by Euripides.
- ▶ *Agamemnon* and *Thyestes* by Seneca.
- ▶ *Two Faces of Oedipus* by Frederick Ahl.

Acknowledgement I

Elektra

Hector Li

Overview

Myth

Synopsis

Favorite Arias

Style and
Instrumentation

Fragmentary
Thoughts on the
Opera Itself

Relations with
Other Works

Trivia and
Anecdotes

Recommended
Reading

Acknowledgement

I am greatly indebted to Professor Ahl for his insights on ancient Greek tragedies, and Wikipedia for the parts on Synopsis and Instrumentation (though the online article has some mistakes).